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Chapter 3: How Are the Attributes of the Promised Generation Achieved?

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Chapter Three: How Are the Attributes of the Promised Generation Achieved?

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When one reflects deeply on the ten previous attributes that form the minimum requirement for what the Promised Generation endowed with victory and empowerment (*al-Jeel al-Maw'ud bi al-nasr wa al-tamkeen*) ought to be, one finds that the realization of these attributes is an extremely difficult matter. If one of us undertakes some of them for a period of time, he will quickly revert to his former condition. And reality is the best proof of that, for many of us wish to be detached from the world (*zahid*), desirous of what is with Allah, eagerly striving for Paradise, sincere to Allah (*mukhlis lillah*), fearful of Him, loving Him... yet he is unable to do so.

We read reports of the righteous and are moved by them, and we dream of being like them, but we are unable to turn the dream into reality. Why?!

Because we want to leap directly to the fruit without beginning the matter from its beginning. Since the stage of fruit-bearing is the last of the stages of cultivation, preceded by many stages of care and attention, likewise the ten previous attributes cannot appear except through work, construction, and inner change that escalates gradually until the signs appear and the fruits ripen.

For example: a person cannot undertake the deeds of those sincere to Allah (*al-mukhlisin lillah*), Exalted and Majestic is He, and persist in that for a period of time, for sincerity (*al-ikhlas*) is nothing but one form of a servant's interaction with his Lord; and it must arise from within him naturally. The same applies to love, fear, hope, glorification, and so on.

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Treatment is Proportionate to Knowledge (*al-mu'amlah bi qadr al-ma'rifah*)

If you ask: how can a servant interact with his Lord in these ways and persist in that throughout his life?!

The answer is that it is commonly known among people that the degree of a person's treatment of another is proportionate to the extent of his knowledge of that other. If, for example, a person were seated next to another on a train traveling to a distant city, and conversation began between the two individuals... at the beginning of the conversation there would be much reserve between them, but with continued acquaintance and the exchanging of conversation, the awkwardness

would fade and the degree of each one's treatment of the other would improve. This is one aspect.

On the other hand, if one of them discovered that the other held a prestigious position, his view of him would change from what it had been at the beginning, and that would undoubtedly be reflected in his manner of dealing with him.

Ignorance of Allah (al-jahl billah)

If we look at our treatment of and relationship with Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, we will find it a cold treatment and a limited relationship. What governs and influences it is the degree of our knowledge of Him, Glorified is He. Were people to know the true magnitude of their Lord, they would fear Him and be upright in obedience to Him: "They did not appraise Allah with true appraisal." (Quran, al-An'am 6:91)

And as the servants' ignorance of Allah increases, their false perception of Him—Glorified is He—increases, and that is reflected in the form of interaction between them and Him.

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Consider, for example, His Exalted saying: "The foolish among the people will say, 'What has turned them away from their qiblah which they used to face?' Say, 'To Allah belongs the east and the west. He guides whom He wills to a straight path.'" (Quran, al-Baqarah 2:142)

The Quran called those who ask this question "the foolish" (al-sufaha') because they do not know Allah, and they do not know that to Him belongs the dominion of the heavens and the earth, that He does what He wills and rules as He pleases.

Another example is His saying: "And the Day the enemies of Allah are gathered to the Fire, and they will be driven in rows. Until, when they reach it, their hearing, their sight, and their skins will testify against them of what they used to do. And they will say to their skins, 'Why have you testified against us?' They will say, 'Allah, who made all things speak, made us speak, and He created you the first time, and to Him you are returned. And you were not covering yourselves, lest your hearing testify against you or your sight or your skins, but you assumed that Allah does not know much of what you do. And that was your assumption which you assumed about your Lord. It has brought you to ruin, and you have become among the losers.'" (Quran, Fussilat 41:19-23)

This limited and deficient perception of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, caused them to stray from His straight path, bringing them to the Fire—and refuge is sought in Allah.

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With Musa, peace be upon him

Reflect with me on this incident that occurred with Musa, peace be upon him: "And when Musa arrived at Our appointed time and his Lord spoke to him, he said, 'My Lord, show me [Yourself] that I may look at You.' [Allah] said, 'You will not see Me, but look at the mountain; if it should remain in place, then you will see Me.' But when his Lord appeared to the mountain, He rendered it level, and Musa fell unconscious. And when he awoke, he said, 'Exalted are You! I have repented to You, and I am the first of the believers.'" (Quran, al-A'raf 7:143)

In this incident, Musa—peace be upon him—asked his Lord to see Him. Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, informed him that he could not see Him and set for him—Glorified and Exalted is He—a proof of that: if He were to manifest Himself to the mountain and the mountain were to remain in its place and nothing happened to it, then Musa would be able to see Him. Then Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, manifested Himself to the mountain, and the mountain was crushed and pulverized. What happened to Musa, peace be upon him?!

He fell unconscious from the terrifying sight he witnessed. Then when he awoke, his knowledge of the greatness and majesty of his Lord had increased, and that knowledge was reflected in his speech and his treatment of his Lord. When he regained consciousness, he said: “Exalted are You! I have repented to You, and I am the first of the believers.”

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Musa, peace be upon him, had repented to Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, from falling short in His right, Glorified is He, from failing to glorify, venerate, and sanctify Him as He deserves, and from asking to see Him. This repentance was the result of the knowledge that increased in him after he saw the effects of Allah’s greatness and glory, Exalted and Majestic is He.

Therefore, treating Allah with sincerity (al-ikhlas), love (al-mahabbah), fear (al-khawf), awe (al-mahabah), glorification (al-ta’zim), piety (al-taqwa), and surrender (al-istislam)—all of that is the product of the strength of knowledge of Him, Glorified is He.

This means that the first axis from which the attributes of the Promised Generation endowed with victory and empowerment should arise is knowledge of Allah (ma’rifat Allah), Exalted and Majestic is He.

The Required Knowledge (al-ma’rifah al-matlabah)

Yes, treatment is proportionate to knowledge; but the knowledge whose presence is required in order to effect change in one’s treatment of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, must be strong, firmly rooted, deep, and continuous.

What is required is knowledge of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, that takes hold of a person’s certainty and inner mind, affects his emotions, and becomes an integral part of his faith (iman).

Knowledge and Faith (al-ma’rifah wa al-iman)

As we know, the source that directs human actions is the heart (al-qalb), and the heart is the gathering place of emotions: love and hatred, desire and dread, joy and pleasure, and so on.

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These Emotions Are Tugged by Two Forces: Faith (iman) and Desire (hawa)

Faith in what the mind contains of realities, and desire for what the soul inclines to and wants... and according to the strength of one of them at the moment of decision, the action will be on its side.

The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, said: “No servant commits adultery while he is a believer; nor does he steal while he is a believer; nor does he drink wine while he is a believer; nor does he kill while he is a believer.”[1]

The moments of adultery, theft, and drinking wine reflected the victory of desire (hawa) over faith (iman).

This means that faith in Allah must increase in the heart so that it may bear righteous deeds through the limbs.

And increasing faith in Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, means increasing the orientation of emotions toward Him, Glorified is He—that is, increasing the orientation of love, dread, awe, and so on.

And as emotions change and turn toward Allah, the servant's inner treatment of his Lord improves, and then that is easily reflected in his outward limbs. Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, said: "That [is so]. And whoever honors the symbols of Allah—indeed, it is from the piety of hearts." (Quran, al-Hajj 22:32)

And the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "O Allah, apportion to us fear of You that prevents us from disobeying You." [2]

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Therefore, the degree of leaving sins is according to the degree of dread... and this dread is nothing but an inner treatment on the servant's part toward his Lord that increases and decreases according to the strength of knowledge of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He.

Thought and Emotion

In order for knowledge of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, to affect the emotions and become part of the individual's faith, it must be deep and effective; it must address both thought and emotion, and it must be continuous so that the emotions may remain directed toward Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He.

Thus, faith in Allah means: knowledge of Allah that affects the emotions, causing the heart to direct this portion of its emotions toward Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He.

As for increasing faith, it means increasing the orientation of emotions toward Him, Glorified is He; and completing faith means the total orientation of emotions toward Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "Whoever loves for Allah, hates for Allah, gives for Allah, and withholds for Allah has completed faith." [3]

From here appears the value of the presence of both mind and heart together in the righteous deeds performed by the servant in order to increase his faith; and according to the degree of movement of the inner emotions along with obedience, the resulting increase in faith is determined.

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This means that the obedience which increases faith is the obedience during which the heart moves; otherwise, however much the servant performs of outward acts of obedience, if his heart does not move with them, the effect resulting from them in increasing faith will be weak, and consequently they will not have a positive effect on the conduct of their doer.

In summary, the first axis from which the attributes of the Promised Generation endowed with victory and empowerment arise is knowledge of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He. This knowledge

must be deep and firmly rooted, increasing faith by it, affecting the emotions, turning them toward Allah; then the inner treatment of Him, Glorified is He, improves, which in turn yields deeds and manifestations that reflect the improvement of this treatment.

Knowledge of the Self (ma'rifat al-nafs)

And just as the principle "treatment is proportionate to knowledge" applies to our relationship with Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, and the manner of our treatment of Him, Glorified is He, it also applies to our view of ourselves and the way we deal with them. What is observed in some people is that they deal with themselves with self-admiration and contentment, sensing their superiority and distinction over others... This erroneous treatment of the self arises from ignorance of its true nature.

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If a person were to know the reality of his origin, the extent of his weakness, his need for his Lord, and the severity of his poverty toward Him... and if he were to know all this with knowledge that becomes entrenched in his certainty and intertwined with his faith, his caution against his own self and his fear of it would intensify, and his sense of need for Allah would intensify.

This means that true knowledge of the self leads to increased sincerity to Allah (al-ikhlas lillah), Exalted and Majestic is He, sincere reliance (al-tawakkul) upon Him, and also produces the attribute of humility (al-tawadu'). For the root of humility is the servant's belittlement of himself and viewing it with the eye of deficiency, and viewing others as better than himself.

From here it becomes clear to us that knowledge of the self is the second axis from which the attributes of the Promised Generation endowed with victory and empowerment arise. This axis is undoubtedly closely connected to the axis of knowledge of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, for the more a servant's knowledge of his Lord increases, the smaller his self becomes in his sight; and the more he forgets his Lord, the more he forgets the danger his self poses to him, and consequently the more he inclines toward it. This is confirmed by His Exalted saying: "And be not like those who forgot Allah, so He made them forget themselves." (Quran, al-Hashr 59:19)

Knowledge of the World (ma'rifat al-dunya)

What is it that makes us covet the world (al-dunya) and think so much about our future? What is the reason for our greed for wealth, our joy at its increase, and our grief at its decrease? What is it that makes us stretch our eyes toward those who have been favored over us in provision, wishing we were like them?

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It is ignorance of the world and its reality, and that it is merely a stopping place where we rest like a traveler rests, a stage among the stages of the journey back to Allah.

It is also ignorance of its nature, and of the reality of its adornment and finery.

This ignorance has made us deal with it in a wrong way: instead of shunning it and not inclining toward it, we have loved it and been eager for it.

Imagine that someone has invited you and your family to spend the summer vacation in his country. You resolve to travel, but you want some information about that country. You research it and ask those familiar with it, and you find that its weather in summer is extremely hot, electricity is constantly cut off, summer diseases spread there frequently, humidity is very high, and thieves and highwaymen fill its roads... What would your reaction be after hearing this news?!

Would you travel to that country, or would your desire turn away from it?!

Undoubtedly you would lose interest in going there, and your desire would turn away from it completely as a result of your knowledge of its reality.

Likewise is the world: the main reason for our attachment to it is a result of our ignorance of its reality.

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Yes, we hear about some of its attributes from time to time and we wish to renounce it, but we are unable, because knowledge must be deep and firmly rooted, entering a person's certainty and affecting his faith, so that it may have a positive and continuous effect on his dealing with it through renunciation (al-zuhd) and turning away from it.

Thus, knowledge of the world is the third axis from which the attributes of the Promised Generation arise, especially the attribute of renunciation (al-zuhd) and similar attributes.

Faith in the Hereafter (al-iman bi al-akhirah)

On the opposite side of our treatment of the world, we deal with the Hereafter (al-akhirah). Despite the Hereafter being the abode of settlement, and despite Paradise containing forms of bliss that the limited human mind cannot comprehend, and despite the Fire containing forms of punishment that no human can bear, we do not deal with this reality as we should. We are not seen eagerly striving for Paradise; rather, we are indifferent to it and to everything that draws near to it. Nor are we seen fearful and trembling of the Fire, or acting to flee from it; and this is undoubtedly a result of ignorance of their reality.

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Indeed, clarity of vision regarding Paradise and the absence of its reality from the mind of the Muslim has a great role in spurring him toward it, and that is reflected in his conduct: hastening to good deeds, increasing in worship, striving in the path of Allah, and being patient over the hardships of the path.

This means that knowledge of the Hereafter and faith in it form the fourth axis from which the attributes of the Promised Generation endowed with victory and empowerment arise.

The Four Knowledges (al-ma'arif al-arba')

Thus, there are four knowledges that form the fundamental starting points for most of the attributes of the Generation of Empowerment (Jeel al-Tamkeen): knowledge of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He; knowledge of the self; knowledge of the world; and knowledge of the Hereafter. Taking into consideration that the required knowledge ought to be deep and firmly rooted in a person's certainty and inner mind, affecting his emotions so that it becomes an integral part of

his faith, driving him to correct interaction with Allah, with the self, with the world, and with the Hereafter; and this yields sincerity to Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, love for Him, fear of Him, increase in worship, humility, renunciation of the world, jihad, sacrifice, patience, steadfastness, obedience, devotion, and reliance upon Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He.

Wisdom as the Fruit of Understanding (al-hikmah thamarat al-fahm)

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As for the attribute of balance and equilibrium (al-i'tidal wa al-tawazun), which is the tenth attribute, it is the fruit of correct and comprehensive understanding of the religion, of its levels and rulings; and it is also the fruit of knowing the fiqh of priorities, the fiqh of balances, the fiqh of reality, the fiqh of objectives, and the fiqh of differences of opinion. Taking into consideration the importance of this axis—the axis of understanding (fiqh)—as a restraint that prevents the deeds from swerving toward extremes that strong faith in Allah and the Last Day, and strong caution against the world and the self, might push one toward.

It is expected that these four knowledges, when they take hold of the servant, may push him to renounce the world or to be harsh with the self and deprive it of some of its lawful pleasures; and they may push him to be severe in matters in which severity is not appropriate, or lenient in matters in which leniency is not appropriate.

From here, wisdom (al-hikmah), balance (al-i'tidal), equilibrium (al-tawazun), and the middle course (al-wasatiyyah) became wholesome fruits of correct understanding of the religion.

This means that correct understanding of Islam is the fifth axis from which the attributes of the Promised Generation endowed with victory and empowerment arise.

Brotherhood (al-ukhuwwah)

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The attribute of brotherhood, bonding, and loyalty to the believers remains... This attribute is nothing but one of the fruits of faith in Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, and a necessary consequence of it; and the more faith in Allah takes hold of the heart, the more love for Allah increases.

Reflect with me on the state of the Ansar when faith took possession of their hearts until they reached the level of which Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, said: "And those who settled in the home [of Madinah] and accepted faith before them." (Quran, al-Hashr 59:9)

It is as if they entered faith with their whole being, so it mixed with their flesh and blood in addition to its taking hold of their hearts. What did this wondrous level of faith produce?

It produced a love for the sake of Allah toward the Muhajirun, the effects of which appeared in deeds unprecedented among human beings: "And those who settled in the home [of Madinah] and accepted faith before them love those who emigrated to them and find not any want in their breasts of what they [the emigrants] were given, but give [them] preference over themselves, even though they are in privation. And whoever is protected from the stinginess of his soul—it is those who will be the successful." (Quran, al-Hashr 59:9)

And what is amazing is that they did all that despite poverty and need, not wealth and ease.

Means of Forming the Axes

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What has become clear to us from the foregoing is that the attributes of the Promised Generation endowed with victory and empowerment are nothing but natural fruits of five knowledges: knowledge of Allah, knowledge of the self, knowledge of the world, knowledge of the Hereafter, and knowledge of the foundations of correct understanding of the religion.

These knowledges must become firmly rooted in the Muslim's certainty, affect his emotions, and draw his faith, so that they may yield the attributes that Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, desires from His servants in a natural and continuous manner.

If the matter is thus, the question remains: How can we form these knowledges in the required manner? The discussion in the following pages revolves around answering this question.

Footnotes

[1] Narrated by al-Bukhari in his Sahih and by Imam Ahmad in his Musnad, from Ibn Abbas.

[2] Hasan. Narrated by al-Tirmidhi and al-Hakim from Ibn Amr, and recorded by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami' no. 1268.

[3] Narrated by Abu Dawud from Abu Hurayrah; also recorded by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami' no. 4674, Sahih. Grade not specified in source.

Chapter 3, Pages 113–127: Knowing Allah and Knowing Oneself

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How Do We Know Allah?!

Knowledge of Allah (ma'rifat Allah), the Mighty and Majestic, is the most important of the five axes necessary for forming the promised generation; and according to the extent of that knowledge are the good fruits and the praiseworthy attributes that we all strive to adorn ourselves with. And why not, for sincerity (al-ikhlas), love (al-mahabbah), fear (al-khawf), hope (al-raja'), reliance (al-tawakkul), seeking aid (al-isti'anah), and... all of these are blessed fruits of deep knowledge of Allah, the Mighty and Majestic.

And on the other hand, weakness of that knowledge leaves many negative effects upon the servant, so you see him fearful of created beings, anxious about his provision, seeking help from other humans in fulfilling his needs, committing many sins...

True Knowledge

Hence, the truly beneficial knowledge that seekers of knowledge in particular — and all Muslims in general — ought to roll up their sleeves for and begin with, is knowledge of Allah, the Mighty and Majestic. For through this knowledge, the servant's treatment of his Lord improves: he fears Him, is mindful of Him, is wary of Him, relies upon Him, hopes in Him, and...

“Indeed, only those among His servants who have knowledge fear Allah.” (Quran, Fatir 35:28)

And according to the extent and strength of these heart dealings, the servant’s closeness to his Lord is determined.

“Indeed, the most noble of you in the sight of Allah is the most righteous of you.” (Quran, al-Hujurat 49:13)

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Hence, knowledge of Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, was given preference over other knowledge. And after knowledge of Allah comes knowledge of His rulings, so that this yields the servant’s establishment of His commands — exalted is He — in the manner He legislated.

How Do We Know Allah?!

Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, informed us that “There is nothing like unto Him.” (Quran, ash-Shuraa 42:11)

And that “Vision does not perceive Him, but He perceives [all] vision.” (Quran, al-An’am 6:103)

And that “And they do not encompass Him in knowledge.” (Quran, Ta-Ha 20:110)

So how can we know Him? —

Yes, none knows Allah but Allah, and none of the created beings is able to know Him — exalted is He — with true knowledge; yet despite that, Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, has made available to us a portion of knowledge about Him through what He has informed us of His beautiful names (al-asma’ al-husna) by which He named Himself — exalted is He — and through His depositing of the effects and manifestations of those names in His universe and His creatures. Thus Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, informed us that He is the Most Merciful (ar-Rahim), and He showed us many effects that indicate the attribute of mercy: the descent of rain, the acceptance of repentance (at-tawbah), forbearance toward the disobedient, and in His Shariah (ash-shari’ah) that He legislated for His servants and what it contains of indications of mercy, and so on.

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And He also informed us that He is the All-Subjugating (al-Qahhar), and among the effects of the attribute of subjugation that He has manifested in His creatures are: the sex of the newborn, his form and his color, ... and among them are sleep, illness, and forgetfulness.

... Thus, the path to knowing Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, begins with seeing the effects of His names and attributes. And the more knowledge of Him — exalted is He — increases:

“[He] who created seven heavens in layers. And among the earths is something similar. The command descends through them, that you may know that Allah is over all things competent and that Allah has encompassed all things in knowledge.” (Quran, at-Talaq 65:12)

The Signs of Allah (ayat Allah)

There is no creature that Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, has created except that it carries a message introducing Him — exalted is He — to humankind. And all that is upon us is to read those messages well, so that our knowledge of our Lord may increase.

“Do they not look into the realm of the heavens and the earth and everything that Allah has created, and [think] that perhaps their appointed time has come near?” (Quran, al-A'raf 7:185)

From this we realize the importance of the worship of reflection (at-tafakkur) and its immense value in acquainting the servant with his Lord and in leading to his good dealings with Him. Reflect with me on the saying of He Who is Exalted:

“Indeed, in the creation of the heavens and the earth and the alternation of the night and the day are signs for those of understanding — who remember Allah while standing, sitting, and [lying] on their sides and reflect on the creation of the heavens and the earth, [saying], ‘Our Lord, You did not create this in vain; exalted are You, so protect us from the punishment of the Fire.’” (Quran, Aal Imran 3:190-191)

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So when these believers — whom the verse mentioned — reflect upon the creatures and what they contain of signs, indications, and lessons, this reflection concerning Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, bears fruit:

“Our Lord, You did not create this in vain,”

and this knowledge produces exaltation and awe for Him:

“Exalted are You; then protect us from the punishment of the Fire.”

Thus, the path of knowledge begins with reflecting upon the creatures of Allah and what they contain of messages introducing [us] to Him — exalted is He — and to His names and attributes.

“Indeed, in the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the alternation of the night and the day, and the ships which sail through the sea with what benefits people, and what Allah has sent down from the heavens of rain by which He gives life to the earth after its death, and He disperses therein every creature, and the shifting of the winds and the clouds controlled between the heaven and the earth, are signs for a people who use reason.” (Quran, al-Baqarah 2:164)

Life Events

Along with the signs of Allah that point to Him, and to His names and attributes, and that are spread throughout His creatures, there comes another form of signs through the messages that He — Glorified and Exalted is He — sends to His servants, messages that run through the course and events of their daily lives. For there is no day that passes upon a human being — any human being — except that in it are several messages directed to him from his Lord, introducing him to Him and reminding him of some of His attributes.

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So from those messages:

Messages of Mercy

And what they indicate of the fact that He — Glorified and Exalted is He — is the Most Merciful (ar-Rahim), the Kind (al-Latif). An example of that is what befalls a person in his day of events such as forgetting an appointment, so he does not go to it, and that becomes a cause for his not being exposed to many problems or dangers. Also, perhaps the fuel of his car runs out at the very moment he finds himself in front of a fuel station.

Messages of Wisdom

And what they indicate of the fact that He — Glorified and Exalted is He — is the All-Wise (al-Hakim). An example of that is one who goes to a place among places while he is not desiring it, and much good then results for him because of his going.

Messages of Warning

And what they indicate of the fact that He — Glorified and Exalted is He — is the Almighty (al-'Azim), the Compeller (al-Jabbar), ... and His saying — exalted is He — indicates them:

"And We do not send the signs except as a warning." (Quran, al-Isra 17:59)

... and examples of that are thunder, lightning, storms, severe heat, eclipses of the sun and moon.

Messages of Support and the Swift, Good Recompense

from Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, such as the easing of affairs, the expansion of the chest, ... and they are indicated by His saying — exalted is He:

"As for he who gives and is mindful [of Allah], and affirms the best [reward] — We will ease him toward ease." (Quran, al-Layl 92:5-7)

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This support and this easing are tied to the uprightness of the servant and his obedience to his Lord; and when he reads those messages well, that is bound to push him toward greater uprightness.

Messages of Punishment

as a recompense for negligence and disobedience. The forms of that are many: difficulty in affairs, constriction of the chest, deprivation of provision, ... and His saying — exalted is He — indicates them:

"Whoever does evil will be recompensed for it." (Quran, an-Nisa 4:123)

So these are six types of divine messages that come to the servant in his day, and they carry in their folds indications that introduce him to Allah, the Mighty and Majestic.

"And He shows you His signs; then which of the signs of Allah do you deny?" (Quran, Ghafir 40:81)

These messages come from Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, to His servants continuously, so that they may awaken from their slumber and rouse from their heedlessness:

"He directs the affair; He details the signs so that you may be certain of the meeting with your Lord." (Quran, ar-Ra'd 13:2)

And the more the servant links the events of his life to Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, the more his knowledge of Him and attachment to Him — exalted is He — increase, and the better his relationship and dealings with Him become, and the greater his indifference to people becomes. And why not, when he sees none but Allah behind everything that happens to him? So if his wife changes toward him and her conduct with him worsens, he sees in that a punishment from Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, and he hastens to seeking forgiveness (al-istighfar) and repentance (at-tawbah); and if the occurrence of something he desires is delayed, he sees the wisdom of Allah behind this delay; and if someone helps him in accomplishing his work, he sees the divine support and easing behind that.

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And thus he links the events of his life to Allah, the Mighty and Majestic; this yields complete sincerity (al-ikhlas) and true truthfulness in turning to Him and in sensing His closeness — exalted is He — to him, so he worships Him as though he sees Him, and his private supplication and seclusion with Him become among the most beloved things to him, and this also leads to indifference to people and cutting off covetousness for what is in their hands.

The Guide to Knowledge

This vast universe and the creatures within it that are innumerable, and these successive, intertwined daily events — the servant may not be good at taking lesson from them and understanding them as coming from Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, which necessitates the existence of a reference and a guide that directs the servant to how to know Allah, and [teaches him] good dealing with His signs... Hence was the need for a guide that guides people and teaches them how to read the cosmic signs and decipher their code, and to infer from them Allah, the Mighty and Majestic... For this purpose came the final divine message (the Qur'an), which Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, sent to all of humanity, and which carries in its folds the keys to happiness, guidance, and healing:

"O mankind, there has come to you instruction from your Lord and healing for what is in the breasts and guidance and mercy for the believers." (Quran, Yunus 10:57)

And among the most important things that this message carries for humankind is: introducing them to their Lord, and to His names, attributes, and their effects from the theoretical side, while

also introducing them to how to link this theoretical knowledge to practical knowledge in the observable universe, so that the theoretical and practical knowledge intertwine, thereby enabling their meaning to take root in the human being's certainty and faith.

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Example

Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, informed His servants that He is able to grant victory to the oppressed by His saying — exalted is He:

"That is so. And whoever has responded to an oppressor with the like of that with which he was oppressed, and then is tyrannized — Allah will surely aid him. Indeed, Allah is Pardoning and Forgiving." (Quran, al-Hajj 22:60)

And He gave His servants evidence from the observable universe for that, so He — exalted is He — said in the verse following the previous verse [and recalling it]:

"That is so. And whoever has responded to an oppressor with the like of that with which he was oppressed, and then is tyrannized — Allah will surely aid him. Indeed, Allah is Pardoning and Forgiving. That is because Allah merges the night into the day and merges the day into the night, and that Allah is Hearing and Seeing." (Quran, al-Hajj 22:60-61)

So the One Who is able to bring the night and day every day is undoubtedly able to do what is lesser than that: granting victory to the oppressed and establishing truth and justice.

And another example:

That Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, informed His Messenger that messengers before him had been mocked, so there was a painful punishment for those mockers. This is from the theoretical side. As for the practical side, the following verse comes to urge us to travel through the earth and investigate the end of those people, so that this concept becomes firmly rooted in us:

"And already were messengers ridiculed before you, but those who mocked them were enveloped by what they used to ridicule. Say, 'Travel through the earth and observe how was the end of the deniers.'" (Quran, al-An'am 6:10-11)

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Thus, the Qur'an is our guide to knowing Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, and the universe is the practical application of Qur'anic knowledge:

"We will show them Our signs in the horizons and within themselves until it becomes clear to them that it is the truth. Is it not sufficient concerning your Lord that He is, over all things, a Witness?" (Quran, Fussilat 41:53)

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How Do We Know Ourselves?!

The second of those axes from which the attributes of the generation of empowerment (jil at-tamkeen) emerge is knowledge of the self (ma'rifat an-nafs). So in light of a person's knowledge of himself is his treatment of it; and the aspects of this knowledge are divided into two categories: knowledge of the reality of the human being, and knowledge of the nature of the self.

So knowledge of the reality of the human being stems from knowing his humble origin, that he is from dust and from despised water:

"Did We not create you from a despised fluid?" (Quran, al-Mursalat 77:20)

And it also stems from seeing how small he is in relation to the universe surrounding him:

"The creation of the heavens and the earth is greater than the creation of mankind, but most of mankind do not know." (Quran, Ghafir 40:57)

.... This human being was created weak in everything... In his constitution, and in the extent of his resistance and endurance, he is weak before illnesses, before desires (ash-shahawat), and before the whispers of Satan (wasawis ash-shaytan)...

And despite his intense weakness, he is also helpless: he cannot bring benefit to himself or ward off harm from it.

And likewise, he is ignorant of the consequences of affairs: he does not know what will happen to him in less than a second...

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And he also cannot sustain himself, or preserve his body's organs, or... Thus he needs someone to undertake his preservation and supply him with the necessities of life... He constantly needs air, or else he perishes; he needs food and water... He needs sleep, or else he loses his balance... He needs the continuous functioning of the heart and the flowing of blood in his veins at a certain ease; he needs and needs...

This human being — contemptible, small, ignorant, weak, helpless, poor — needs someone to protect him, teach him, strengthen him, ward off dangers from him, and supply him with the means of life moment by moment.

And who possesses the power to do that except Allah, the Mighty and Majestic?!

"Say, 'Who provides for you from the heaven and the earth? Or who controls hearing and sight and who brings the living out of the dead and brings the dead out of the living and who arranges [every] matter?' They will say, 'Allah.' So say, 'Will you not then fear Him?'" (Quran, Yunus 10:31)

The Nature of the Self

And despite the human being being described by these attributes, the self (an-nafs) has a nature that contradicts them. For it is a stingy self that loves to monopolize every good:

"And the souls were brought forward [for accountability], [showing] stinginess." (Quran, an-Nisa 4:128)

It has a tendency toward transgression (al-fujur) and tyranny (at-tughyan)... It loves superiority (al-'uluw) and distinction from others... It always desires comfort and hates hardships and burdens.

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It wants its desire and its share from every deed the servant does. So if the deed does not serve its desires of comfort, laziness, and enjoyment of apparent pleasures, it eagerly seeks to obtain its hidden desires through the good deeds that the servant performs — by pushing him to praise it, be pleased with it, rejoice in it, and believe in its capacities and capabilities, and [to believe] that through it he does what he wants, distinguishes himself from others, and rises above them. And this is among the loftiest things by which the self delights, becomes elated, and is intoxicated.

The Importance of Knowing the Self

So when a person is ignorant of his reality and of the attributes with which he was innately created — weakness, helplessness, ignorance, and need — he will, without doubt, forget his Lord, and he will not deal with Him as the poor, needy, humble, weak, ignorant [servant] deals [with Him], one who knows that his standing, protection, guidance, preservation, and... all of that are in the hand of his Master (mawla).

And when a person is ignorant of the nature of his self, he surrenders to it, praises it for its deeds, admires it, strives to please it, becomes angry on its behalf, and seeks its help in his works. Thus it grows great in his eyes and becomes arrogant, while in contrast the worth of people shrinks in his view; this leads to his conceit, arrogance, and then his ruin.

... From this it becomes clear to us the importance of knowing the self with a firm knowledge that enters into the human being's certainty and is reflected in his feelings through constant caution against it.

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How Do We Know Ourselves? —

From the mercy of Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, toward His servants is His constant reminding them of their reality and the nature of their selves, and that is through His daily messages that He sends to them. And from these messages:

1. You Are Weak

And that is when Allah, the Mighty and Majestic, leaves us to our weakness and does not help us in resisting what we face: such as illness, the whispers of Satan, evil thoughts, excessive eating, and looking at women...

2. You Are Ignorant

And this message is represented by His saying — exalted is He:

"And if I knew the unseen, I could have acquired much wealth, and no harm would have touched me." (Quran, al-A'raf 7:188)

And among its examples is: when you eat something and it causes you illness — had you known the unseen, you would not have eaten it; and likewise when the vehicle breaks down on the road, or the utensils break...

3. **You Are Helpless**

You have no say in the matter at all... You want to sleep immediately but you cannot; you want to remember something but you are unable... You want a son but your wife gives birth to a daughter... and so on...

4. **You Are Poor**

You have no self-sufficiency from Allah for the blink of an eye; and the examples of this message are many, and no day is free of them. An example of that is the increased palpitation of the heart, so that you realize the extent of your need for your Lord in preserving the heart, caring for it, and keeping it beating at a certain level,

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and also an eyelash entering your eye, or a muscle twitch in one of your muscles, or a trembling of the hands, or... all of these are reminder messages of the reality of your poverty and the extent of your need for your Master (mawla), and that if you were left for the blink of an eye to manage your affairs alone, you would perish.

Thus, the essential means for knowing the reality of the human being is his taking heed and his good dealing with the divine messages that come to him continuously through the events of life, and taking lesson from them.

As for the nature of the self — its love of transgression (al-fujur) and superiority (al-'uluw) — there is no doubt that following its thoughts and its insistence upon us to delay fulfilling a right among rights, or to push us to commit a forbidden act, has a great role in making us aware of its danger and then being cautious of it.

The Role of the Qur'an

These foregoing truths always need reminding, for otherwise the human being is by nature forgetful; and often the events of life pass by him without his taking lesson from them or making them a means to increase his knowledge of himself and the extent of his need for his Lord... From here comes the role of the Qur'an as a great means for the continual introduction of the human being to his reality and the nature of his self, through what it does of blending thought with emotion, and through what it presents of practical examples and stories of past peoples — whether they were righteous, who dealt well with their selves, or corrupt, who surrendered to them and were destroyed.

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And in summary: the means of knowing the self are the Qur'an and the events of life.

Sources

Quranic passages cited in this chunk (all references verified against the Arabic source):

- Quran, Fatir 35:28
- Quran, al-Hujurat 49:13
- Quran, ash-Shuraa 42:11
- Quran, al-An'am 6:103
- Quran, Ta-Ha 20:110
- Quran, at-Talaq 65:12
- Quran, al-A'raf 7:185
- Quran, Aal Imran 3:190-191
- Quran, al-Baqarah 2:164
- Quran, al-Isra 17:59
- Quran, al-Layl 92:5-7
- Quran, an-Nisa 4:123
- Quran, Ghafir 40:81
- Quran, ar-Ra'd 13:2
- Quran, Yunus 10:57
- Quran, al-Hajj 22:60-61
- Quran, al-An'am 6:10-11
- Quran, Fussilat 41:53
- Quran, al-Mursalat 77:20
- Quran, Ghafir 40:57
- Quran, Yunus 10:31
- Quran, an-Nisa 4:128
- Quran, al-A'raf 7:188

No hadith are cited in this chunk.

Chapter 3: How Are the Attributes of the Promised Generation Achieved? (Pages 128–144)

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How Do We Believe in the Hereafter?

It is of great importance to know the stages of man's journey to Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, and to the Hereafter (al-akhirah), and to know the nature of the stage of worldly life (al-dunya) and its relationship to the Hereafter. In light of this knowledge, the servant's attentiveness and rolling up of his sleeves for Paradise (al-jannah) will take place.

The Fundamental Task

Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, sent us down to earth to perform a specific task, namely His worship and servitude (ubudiyyah) to Him in the unseen (al-ghayb); whoever succeeds in performing this task wins Paradise, and whoever fails is punished by imprisonment in the Fire (al-nar), and we seek refuge with Allah.

The world is nothing but a house of test: “Indeed, We have made that which is on earth an adornment for it, that We may test them as to which of them is best in deed.” (Quran, al-Kahf 18:7)

What is required of man — any man — is that he obey his Lord, follow His law, carry out His commands, and avoid His prohibitions,

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and what is also required of him is that he deal well with the means and tools that Allah gives him or withholds from him. In the case of being given and provided with various blessings, what is required of the servant is gratitude (shukr), and that is through praising Allah for His blessings, not being tyrannical because of them, feeling grateful toward Him, Exalted is He, frequently humbling himself before Him, and not being arrogant over others or feeling superior to them.

As for in the case of being deprived of some blessings, such as being deprived of children, abundant provision, or security, what is required of the servant is patience (sabr), so he does not resent, complain, or object to the decree of Allah.

This test begins from the age of puberty to the moments of death and the extraction of the soul, and through the righteous deeds and correct answers that the servant performs, his reward will be in the Hereafter, and his bliss in Paradise: “And whoever does righteousness — then for themselves they are preparing.” (Quran, al-Rum 30:44)

As for the supervision over the test, Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, undertakes it Himself, for He is the Watchful Witness: “Indeed, Allah is ever, over you, an Observer.” (Quran, al-Nisa’ 4:1)

And the angels record the answers: “He does not speak a word but that there is with him a ready observer.” (Quran, Qaf 50:18)

Rather, the body itself testifies against its owner: “On a Day when their tongues, their hands, and their feet will testify against them as to what they used to do.” (Quran, al-Nur 24:24)

This test may end at any time, so the servant must always be ready for the moment of its end so that he does not lose his Hereafter.

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After death comes the stage of the barzakh (barzakh), then the resurrection (al-baith) and the Day of Judgment (yawm al-qiyamah), with its tremendous events and reckoning for all people concerning the task they were asked to perform; after the reckoning, the successful will depart to Paradise, and the failing ones will be driven to the Fire, and we seek refuge with Allah.

In Paradise there will be bliss that no mind can grasp the essence of, and along with lasting bliss there will be eternity without death; and in the Fire — and we seek refuge with Allah — there will be unbearable punishment that does not end: “It will not be eased for them, and they will be therein in despair.” (Quran, al-Zukhruf 43:75)

This means that any reasonable person must have his ultimate ambition there in Paradise, and must work to win it and enjoy its bliss, and must search for the means that lead to that; and the most important of these means is utilizing everything within his reach to make it a means of achieving his goal.

The Traveler’s Rest

These realities require constant attentiveness, wakefulness, and clarity of vision regarding the reality of the world — that it is a house of passage and a test — and that we were not sent down to it to remain in it, but rather to spend some time in it and then leave it and depart, like a traveler who rests from the fatigue of travel at any rest stop he meets along the road.

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This traveler will think only of stocking up with what benefits him in his journey and brings him to his goal and objective. Likewise, the world is nothing but one of the stations of the journey to the Hereafter, and we must stock up from it with what benefits us there.

If you say: We all know that, but we forget it amid the successive events of life, so how can our remembrance and attentiveness to these realities endure [1]?

The solution lies in three means:

First: taking lesson from those who preceded us, frequently thinking about death and visiting graves, reflecting on the conditions of their occupants and how the Angel of Death came to them without them being ready to meet him, and sensing their regret at wasting the opportunity that was in their hands [1],

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and remembering their wishes, which are confined to returning to the world even for a single moment in which they would glorify Allah or seek His forgiveness. The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: “Two light rak’ahs that you belittle or consider insignificant, added by this — he pointed to a grave — to one’s deeds, are dearer to him than the rest of your world.” [2]

Second: frequent reading of the Quran and reflecting on its meanings. It is observed that discussion of the Hereafter, the Day of Reckoning, the bliss of Paradise, the punishment of the grave, the nature of existence in the world, and urging people to race to Paradise — all of this occupies a large space in the Quran, and hardly a surah is free of it, so that it leads to certainty in those matters: “No! If you only knew with knowledge of certainty, you would surely see the Hellfire.” (Quran, al-Takathur 102:5–6)

Thus when a person becomes certain of these realities, that will be reflected in his conduct and the way he deals with the elements of life; you will see him striving, worshipping, rolling up his sleeves to do good deeds, and treating others well.

Third: righteous companionship (al-suhbah al-salihah). Along with taking lesson from those around us and remembering death, and with constant reflection on the Quran, the mutual reminding among believers of these realities comes as a means that helps the servant maintain his wakefulness, attentiveness, and good preparation for death, as the Exalted said to His Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him: “And keep yourself patient with those who call upon their Lord morning and evening,

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seeking His countenance; and let not your eyes pass beyond them, desiring adornments of the worldly life, and do not obey one whose heart We have made heedless of Our remembrance and who follows his desire and whose affair is ever in neglect.” (Quran, al-Kahf 18:28)

Indeed, a person's being in a wholesome environment and righteous companionship tends to stir his ambition to race toward the Gardens. Look at Umar ibn al-Khattab, may Allah be pleased with him, and his keenness to outstrip Abu Bakr al-Siddiq, may Allah be pleased with him, in spending. He said, may Allah be pleased with him: "The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, commanded us one day to give charity, and that coincided with my having some wealth, so I said: Today I will outstrip Abu Bakr, if I can outstrip him. So I came to the Messenger of Allah with half of my wealth, and the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: 'What have you left for your family?' I said: The like of it. He said: And Abu Bakr came with all that he had, so the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: 'What have you left for your family?' He said: 'I have left for them Allah and His Messenger.' I said: 'I will never compete with you over anything ever again.'" [3]

These means and others increase faith in the Hereafter in the heart and spur one to strive and roll up his sleeves for Paradise.

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How Do We Practice Zuhd in the World?

There is no doubt that the servant's knowledge of the world in its true reality plays a major role in his asceticism (zuhd) and the turning away of his desire from it, and in increasing his desire for what is with Allah, the Exalted and Majestic.

And whoever reads the verses and hadiths that describe the world will be amazed at the intensity of its contemptibility to Allah, the Exalted and Majestic. If you are in doubt about this, then reflect with me on this hadith.

"Indeed, Allah, the Exalted, has made what comes out of the children of Adam a parable for the world." [4]

Al-Mustawrid ibn Shaddad said: "I was with the group who stopped with the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, at the dead sheep, and the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: 'Do you see how contemptible this is to its owners, so that they threw it away?' They said: Who would throw it away because of its contemptibility, O Messenger of Allah? He said: 'By the One in whose hand is the soul of Muhammad, the world is more contemptible to Allah than this is to its owners.'" [5]

Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, created the world and did not give it any value, nor did He esteem it by the slightest thing, as he, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "If the world were equal in the sight of Allah to the wing of a mosquito, He would not have given the disbeliever a sip of water from it." [6]

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Thus the world is contemptible, of no value, like a stinking carcass that people loathe and avoid passing near; if they are forced to do so, you see them hastening their steps and turning their faces away from it.

The House of Grief and Sorrows

Along with this amazing reality of the world, it is, beyond that, never pure for anyone; it is full of turbidness: joys are followed by sorrows, well-being is pursued by sickness, strength is followed

by weakness. The gathering of loved ones is not complete in it, for if they gather, separation is inevitable for them.

If you say: Why then did Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, create it with this contemptibility and that turbidness? The answer came from the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him: "Whoever loves his world harms his Hereafter, and whoever loves his Hereafter harms his world. So prefer what remains over what perishes." [7]

So if the world had a considerable value, and if it were free of its turbidness and pure, people would love it and become attached to it, which would lead to their competing and struggling over it, and increased eagerness to remain in it; thus their hatred of death would increase, and their desire for the Hereafter and its bliss would decrease, so their trade would stagnate and their deeds would be abandoned.

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This means that the world's being in this contemptible state and with that turbidness is a great blessing from Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, to His servants. For if the world were pure, no one would roll up his sleeves for the Hereafter; yet despite that, Satan has been able to deceive very many people and make them forget these realities, and to adorn the world for them and display it before them so that they lean toward it, cling to it, and struggle over it, and forget the mission for which they were created.

Means of Knowledge

As was said previously, for these realities to be a motive for changing a person's dealing with his world and for his asceticism in it, they must take hold of his certainty and affect his faith. Hence, it was necessary for there to be strong and continuous means that carry out this task.

These means proceed — like the previous means — from two axes: an emotional axis that constantly reminds one of the reality of the world, blending thought with emotion, stirring feelings, and generating the driving energy for action; and a practical axis that confirms the emotional meaning, thereby embedding its significance in a person's certainty so that his perceptions, concerns, and consequently his actions flow easily and spontaneously, expressing his asceticism in the world.

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As for the theoretical axis capable of constant reminding of the reality of the world, it is the Eternal Book that Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, sent down as mercy and guidance for people: "And thus We have sent it down as an Arabic Quran, and have varied therein the warnings, that they might fear Allah or it would cause them to remember." (Quran, Ta Ha 20:113)

It is observed in the Quran that the subject of the world and its reality occupies a large space in it, through describing it, censuring those who are eager for it, and presenting stories of previous peoples who were deluded by it and regretted that most intensely after their death.

Along with the Quran comes the Sunnah likewise, and what it contains of numerous hadiths that speak of the reality of the world and call to asceticism in it.

As for the practical axis, it is taking lesson from the events of the world: the careful observer of the events of life and what happens to people sees the world in its reality, and that it is a house of sorrows, worries, griefs, turbidness, and separation.

Thus the people of strength yesterday are the weak ones today, and status and authority have never lasted for anyone.

Hardly a house is free of someone sick, and it is rare to see a person without worries or griefs. Loved ones separate: a son leaves his father and marries, and a father leaves his sons and dies, and ...

When the servant views these scenes with the eye of reflection, the reality of the world will always be manifested before him.

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And among the things that embed this meaning in the soul is looking at garbage dumps and carcasses every so often and connecting that with the reality of the world and its contemptibility to Allah, as the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, and his noble Companions used to do.

It was narrated from al-Hasan al-Basri that he said: "Umar ibn al-Khattab passed by a garbage dump and stopped at it, and it was as if that pained his companions and they were hurt by it, so he said to them: This is your world that you are so eager for." [8]

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How Is Proper Understanding of Religion Achieved?

As for the qualities of moderation and balance, and what they yield of wisdom in dealing with the events of life, they are nothing but a natural product of proper understanding of religion, as the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "Whoever Allah wishes good for, He gives him understanding (fiqh) in religion." [9]

The intended meaning of proper understanding of religion is realizing the reality of its comprehensiveness for all aspects of life, knowing the sources of legal rulings and their levels, and also recognizing the non-legislative sources that some rely on in receiving rulings, such as inspiration and dreams, and how serious that is.

Proper understanding of religion also requires knowledge of the jurisprudence of priorities (fiqh al-awlawiyyat) and how to balance and give precedence between benefits and harms when they conflict, for as Shaykh al-Islam Ibn Taymiyyah said: "The intelligent one is not the one who knows good from evil, but rather the intelligent one is the one who knows the better of two goods and the worse of two evils." [10]

Along with the jurisprudence of priorities, there is the jurisprudence of objectives (fiqh al-maqasid), the jurisprudence of reality (fiqh al-waqi), and the jurisprudence of disagreement (fiqh al-khilaf). All of these are matters that contribute to forming the balanced mentality of the sons of the generation promised victory and empowerment.

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Means of Achieving Understanding

Among the most important means of achieving proper understanding of religion is the Noble Quran, for it is a Book that addresses the intellect, in which it draws the map of Islam with its

correct proportions, and gives its possessor a comprehensive conception of everything required of him and his relationship to everything around him; and it is not content with that, but places every matter in its appropriate size within the tree of Islam, for it arranges priorities and forms a moderate, balanced mentality that gives every right-holder his due. The Exalted said: "And whoever is given wisdom has certainly been given much good." (Quran, al-Baqarah 2:269)

Ibn Abbas said: "Wisdom is knowledge of the Quran." [11]

Along with the Quran, there are studies by scholars on the principles of understanding, and perhaps the most prominent of these is what al-Shatibi wrote in his book *al-Muwafaqat* and what Imam al-Shahid Hasan al-Banna wrote in *Risalat al-Ta'alim*, in which he laid down principles of understanding. These principles have been explained by many scholars, and they generally form the balanced scholarly personality of the Muslim.

It is also good to study the jurisprudence of priorities and objectives, and the jurisprudence of disagreement, while taking into account that grounding proper understanding of Islam and learning wisdom in dealing with the events of life require — along with the previous means — a teacher [11].

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and a murabbi (teacher-mentor) who waters this knowledge into his students and follows them in their dealings with the course of events to make sure of their proper application of the quality of moderation and balance.

Brotherhood... How Is It Achieved?

Brotherhood (ukhuwwah) in Allah is a natural fruit of the fruits of faith in Him, Exalted is He, and a necessary consequence of it; and the more faith takes root in the heart, the greater the degree of love for Allah's sake, as was the case of the Ansar (the Helpers) with the Muhajirun (the Emigrants). Their strong faith in their Lord was reflected in their dealings with their Muhajirun brothers to the extent that they preferred them over themselves, despite their own poverty and need.

Thus the quality of brotherhood and bonding is a product of the first axis, which is knowledge of Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, and what it leads to of strong faith and love for Him, Exalted is He; and yet this love must be translated into actions that embed its meaning in a person's certainty, for just as faith is word and deed, so is brotherhood.

Hence it becomes necessary to have an environment and a setting in which the means and works of brotherhood are practiced: mutual support (takafull), assistance, preferring others (ithar), striving to fulfill needs, and ...

And there must be an environment and incubators in which brotherhood and bonding are nurtured among the sons of the generation promised victory and empowerment, otherwise the spirit will dry up among individuals.

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The Basic Means

From what has preceded, it is clear to us that the means by which the basic axes for forming the promised generation are achieved revolve around: good dealing with the Quran and everything

that serves it, good dealing with the events of life and taking lesson from them, and righteous companionship.

Thus the Quran is the effective means of knowledge: knowledge of Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, knowledge of the self, knowledge of the world, and knowledge of the Hereafter.

What distinguishes the knowledge of the Quran is that it is repeated in many surahs in various styles, addressing both the intellect and the emotions, so that through this those knowledges are embedded in a person's certainty and his feelings are directed toward them, producing a living, strong faith.

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As for the events of life: everything that happens to a person is by the will of Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, and there is no will of Allah except that behind it is a wisdom that flows into the benefit of mankind, as the Exalted said: "Indeed, Allah is, to the people, Kind and Merciful." (Quran, al-Baqarah 2:143)

So life is nothing but successive messages from Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, by which He makes us know Him, Exalted is He, ourselves, the value of the world, and the value of the Hereafter. "And how many signs in the heavens and earth do they pass over while they turn away from them." (Quran, Yusuf 12:105)

But through good dealing with the Quran, and the gradual attentiveness that will occur to the individual as a product of this dealing, it will become easy for him to read the divine messages and take lesson from them, to understand well concerning Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, and to connect the events of life to Him, so that knowledge and certainty in Him, Exalted is He, and in the Hereafter increase, and caution against the self and the world increases.

As for righteous companionship, it is considered the environment through which the sons of the promised generation practice the quality of brotherhood, producing a strong, bonded generation like a building whose parts reinforce one another.

And through righteous companionship and the educational environment, some means are also practiced that help increase the previous knowledges and connect them to reality, so that faith and attentiveness increase.

In it, everything that serves the Quran and confirms the wisdom and faith-based meanings in it is studied, such as the Seerah (prophetic biography), history, and principles of understanding; and through it, mutual counsel toward truth and patience takes place, and individuals support one another.

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The Murabbi

Along with these three means — "the Quran — reflection — companionship" — comes the role of the teacher (mu'allim) and the murabbi (teacher-mentor) to bind the means to one another. He takes the weak by the hand until his resolve becomes firm and enters him into the world of the Quran, until the resources of faith are renewed in him, and he is able to reflect on the events of life, read the divine messages, and draw near to his Lord.

The presence of the murabbi is also important for sharpening ambitions to roll up one's sleeves for the Hereafter and to practice asceticism in the world.

And among his most important roles are: regulating understanding among individuals, teaching them wisdom, and making sure they practice it well in the course of their lives.

Footnotes

[1] A speaker may say that this talk contradicts the concept of building up the earth (imarat al-ard) and the crafting of life that Allah has called us to. Yes — it would contradict if the intended meaning of building up the earth were clinging to the world, enjoying it, and forgetting the Hereafter, as was the case of the people of Ad, whom their prophet Hud rebuked for that: "Do you build on every elevation a sign, amusing yourselves, and take for yourselves palaces and fortifications, that you might abide eternally?" (Quran, al-Shu'ara' 26:128–129). But if the intended meaning of building up the earth is benefiting from its treasures and the laws of harnessing them in order to increase knowledge of Allah, the Exalted and Majestic, on one hand, and to ease life for people so that their performance of worship becomes easier as a result on the other hand, then this is, without doubt, a praiseworthy matter for which its doer is rewarded.

[2] Reported by al-Albani in *al-Silsilah al-Sahihah*, no. 1288.

[3] Hasan; narrated by al-Tirmidhi, al-Darimi, and Ibn Asakir.

[4] Hasan; narrated by Imam Ahmad and al-Tabarani, and graded hasan by al-Albani in *Sahih al-Jami'*, no. 1739.

[5] Narrated by al-Tirmidhi, who said: hasan sahih hadith. *Al-sakhilah*: the young of a goat or sheep.

[6] Narrated by al-Tirmidhi, who said: hasan hadith.

[7] Narrated by Ahmad, al-Bazzar, al-Tabarani, Ibn Hibban, and al-Hakim, who graded it sahih.

[8] *Al-Zuhd* by Imam Ahmad, p. 118, Dar al-Kutub al-Ilmiyyah, Beirut.

[9] Agreed upon (muttafaq alayh).

[10] *Majmu' al-Fatawa* by Ibn Taymiyyah, 20/549, Dar al-Ifta, Saudi Arabia.

[11] *Tafsir al-Qur'an al-Azim* by Ibn Kathir, 1/283.